

THE COSMOS

Just as our world is split into different countries with their own beliefs and cultures, so too is the mythical realm of the Norse. Their cosmos is made up of nine worlds. The gods oversee, and often meddle with, some of these worlds – yet they have no access to others, such as Muspelheim. At the centre of it all is Yggdrasil, the World Tree, binding everything together.

GINNUNGAGAP

Before the creation of the cosmos, there was only Ginnungagap. Life sprang forth from this yawning void when the freezing winds and ice of the north met and mixed with the sizzling sparks and fire from the south.



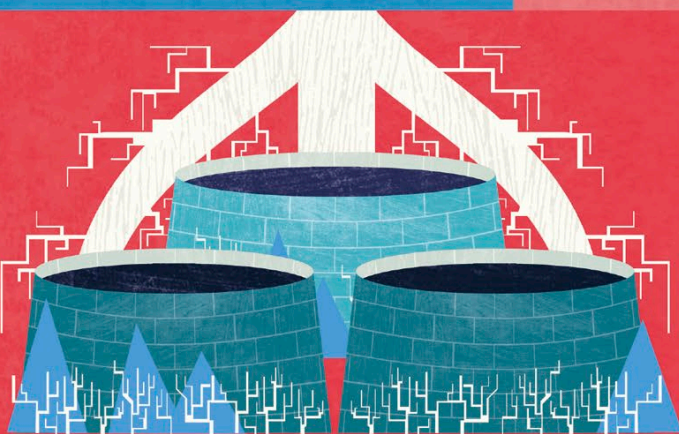
YGGDRASIL

This great ash tree stands in the centre of the cosmos, holding the worlds together in its roots and branches. Rivers spring from it, and concealed beneath is Mimir's Well, source of all wisdom.



BIFROST

The Rainbow Bridge is a magical link allowing the gods to travel to and from Midgard. The all-seeing god Heimdall guards it from invaders, but it's destined to be destroyed at Ragnarök.



THREE WELLS AND THREE ROOTS

Yggdrasil has three long and twisting roots, each connected to a well. The first reaches the Well of Urd in Asgard, where the three Norns live. The second reaches Mimir's Well in Jotunheim. The third reaches Hvergelmir, the "bubbling cauldron", found in Niflheim.



INNANGARD AND UTANGARD

The Norse believed in two opposing ways of being: *innangard*, meaning "within the enclosure", and *utangard*, or "outside the enclosure". The ordered, civilized gods and humans lived *innangard*, while the more chaotic, wild giants, dwarfs and elves lived *utangard*.